

Community

Check out what our Digit Squad members churned out this month including the XOLO Q800 and more

Digit101

A non-photographer's complete guide to the jargon that's involved in photographers l33t speak

Of accidental inventions

If you thought all the invented wonders of our world were thanks to the efforts of thousands of man hours spent closeted inside a science lab somewhere, you couldn't be more wrong. Well, not all of them, at least. A few inventions happened by pure accident. Or was it aliens?

**Saccharin**

One can be forgiven to think that this sweet sugar substitute was invented by a diabetic. Instead it was chanced upon by a chemist experimenting on coal-tar derivatives – hardly an appetizing topic. An experimental compound spilled on his hand made everything he ate taste sweet that day. It made him think and retrace his steps. The rest is history.

Viagra

Viagra's remarkable invention was spearheaded by a *common side-effect* noticed while testing Pfizer's drug on high blood pressure and a heart condition. The pharmaceutical firm instead of ignoring this *common complaint*, seized on the opportunity to explore a whole new market. Men all over can't thank them enough. Probably women too.

**Microwave oven**

It would sound a little absurd that the first microwave oven was an accidental invention triggered by a magnetron (instrument to power radars) inspection. But when a candy bar melted in Percy Spencer's trouser pocket, while standing next to a magnetron, he studied the effects of microwave. And got the brainwave for a kitchen appliance.

**Potato chips**

Believe it or not but the very first potato chips ever made were meant to be an insult. As the story goes, in 1853, a cranky guest complained about a chef's soggy fried potato slices. The chef decided to get back at the customer by slicing the next batch of potatoes paper-thin, frying them to a crisp and sprinkling too much salt. But the customer loved it. History!

X-rays

Wilhelm Röntgen was dabbling with cathode-ray tubes, but despite covering it with cardboard he found a chemical glowing near the machine. How can this be when it's fully covered and no light escaped? As we've all read in our school science text books, Röntgen named these mysterious waves as X-rays and they've been immensely useful in medicine.

**Popsicle**

Ah, sweet summer delight. While popsicles are synonymous with summer days, they were actually chanced upon by an 11-year-old boy who forgot his fruit-flavoured soda in a cup with a stirring stick outside his house in the middle of winter. When he saw what his drink had transformed into the next morning, a whole new ice addiction was born.